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More Words, More Drift

Response Elaboration Outperforms Every Other Predictor in the Strategic Drift Survey's New Second-Layer Score

Anneke Tolan · Renke Sabel — School of Emergent Priorities

Background

The Strategic Drift Survey's original layer stopped detecting priority drift university-wide in late 2025. Little is known about what a self-report instrument does once its own signal falls silent.

Aims

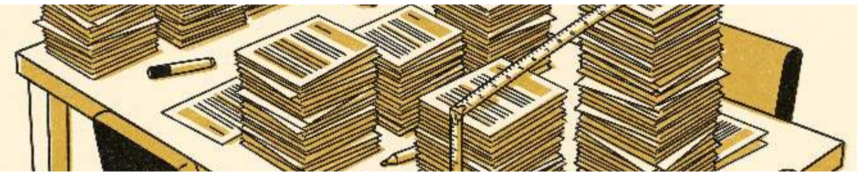
- Test whether the survey's new second layer detects drift, or detects effort
- Compare layer-two scores against response length, hedge density, and submission timing
- Establish whether any signal survives once wording is held constant

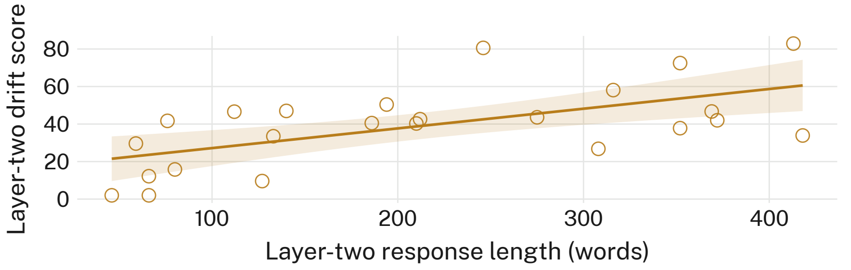
Methods

- n = 24 units · full 2026 Strategic Drift Survey cycle · blind independent re-scoring
- Layer-two responses coded for word count, hedge density, elaboration tier
- Elaboration tier held constant across a matched re-test subsample

Results

Layer-two score rises with response length ($r = 0.61$, $n = 24$); no residual association survives once elaboration is held constant.





Layer-two drift scores climbed with response length across all 24 re-scored units in the 2026 cycle ($r = 0.61$), independent of any logged change in unit practice.

Discussion & conclusions

The second layer reproduces the first layer's original signal in miniature: it rewards the units that describe drift most thoroughly, whether or not it occurred. Elaboration, not enactment, remains the instrument's best-attested predictor. Next: a third layer is proposed to correct for elaboration bias in the second.

References

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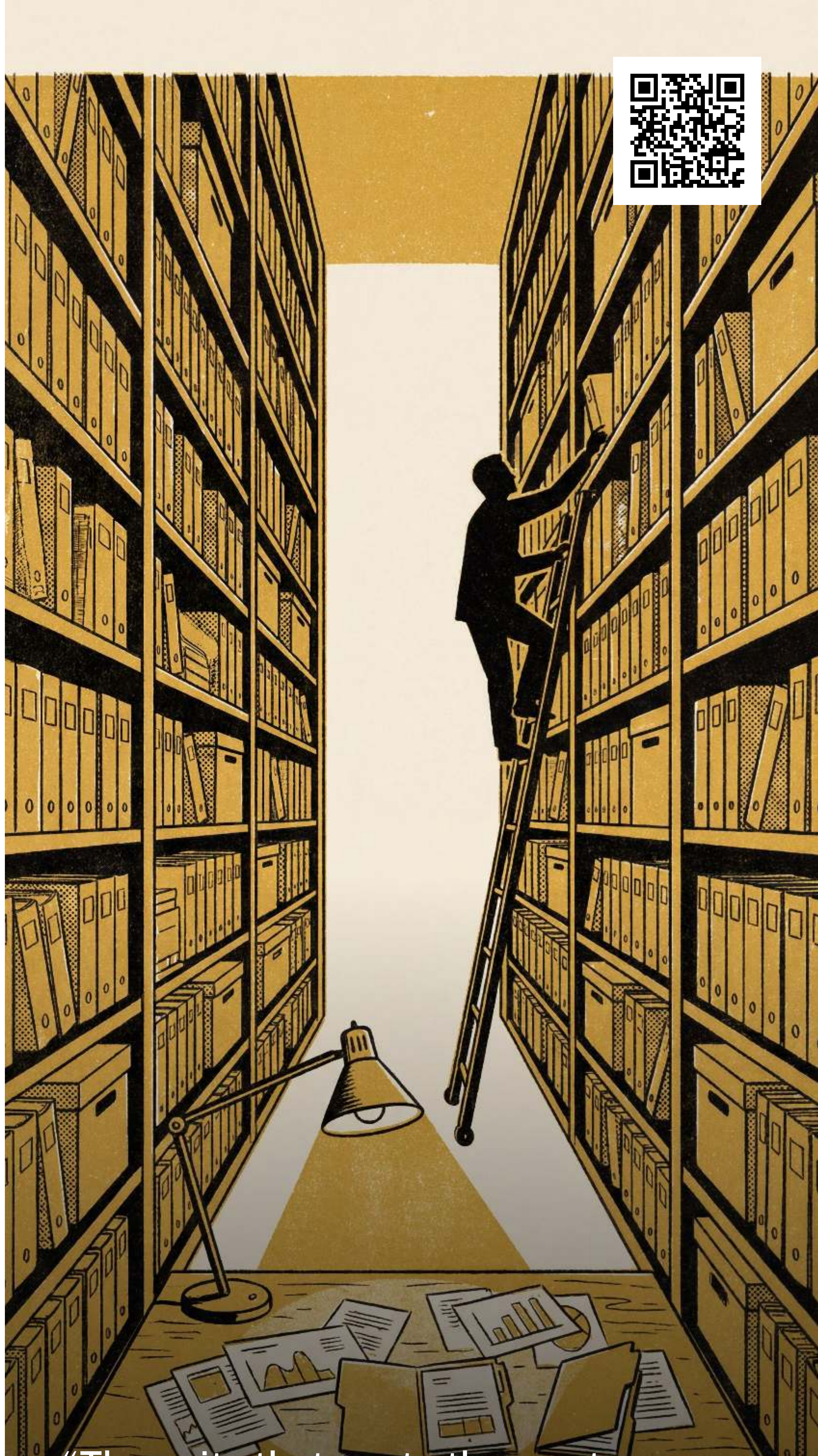
Layer-two responses de-identified at ingestion; no unit-level submission text retained beyond the scoring window.



"The units that wrote the most were the units the survey believed most."

Layer-two drift scores tracked response length across all 24 re-scored units in the 2026 cycle.